

50TH ANNIVERSARY
SPORTS
1995-2005

VISHWANATHAN ANAND

The Chess Grandmaster became world champion upon winning the 2000 FIDE World Chess Championship

ANAND BECAME THE FIRST SPORTSPERSON TO RECEIVE THE PADMA VIBHUSHAN, INDIA'S SECOND-HIGHEST CIVILIAN HONOUR, IN 2007

in world cricket, it was also one where individual sports finally got their moment in the sun—tennis, chess, weightlifting, athletics, shooting, each championed with aplomb on and beyond the national stage after decades of private gestation and self-doubt.

Fans remember well the moment when Leander Paes broke India's 16-year-long record of winning nothing at the Olympics with a bronze in men's singles in 1996—tacking on top of that the dual honour of being the only Indian and first Asian at the Olympics to win a medal in the sport. Three years later, he and Mahesh Bhupathi formed the first doubles team in 50 years to reach the finals of all four Grand Slam tournaments in the same calendar year, also clinching two of them. The early 2000s also saw the Sania Mirza phenomenon come smashing out of the void, creating a space all her own.



The King
Jan. 8, 2001

> "The Spaniard whose name was Alexei Shirov had spent a good portion of the past hour holding his head like a man with a migraine. He looked up, wearily shook his head and grimaced. He had barely stretched out his hand before the other man, moving as quickly as he plays, got out of his chair, shook hands with the most restrained of smiles. The crowd in the room began to clap and surge towards the table in one great, grey wave."

Right on cue for the 21st century, Andhra native Karnam Malleswari punched through the glass ceiling in 2000 by becoming the first Indian weightlifter to win an Olympics medal. Having hefted a total of 240 kg for the bronze, she was also the first Indian woman to climb an Olympic podium, drawing on the experience of numerous international titles won in relative obscurity and now on her way to inspiring a generation that includes Mirabai Chanu, Sushil Kumar, Geeta Phogat and Bajrang Punia.

Anju Bobby George wasn't far behind when she long-jumped into the history books with a bronze at